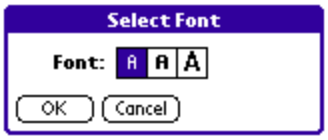
Palm OS Programming Recipes

Push Buttons (aka Radio Buttons)



Push buttons display several choices simultaneously and give the user visual feedback that only one can be chosen at a time. Desktop systems usually accomplish this by radio buttons; push buttons use the same UI concept but with a different, more compact look.

There are several alternatives to using push buttons, such as using a list, or a pop-up list. You normally use push buttons for a static list of short choices. They can be better than pop-up lists because they require one less tap by the user.

To create a set of push buttons in Constructor:

1. Drag the number of required push buttons from the catalog to a form, and set their labels and object identifiers. Ideally, all push buttons are the same width and should be able to fit on one line. They should overlap slightly, such that there is only a single pixel line between adjacent choices. (See the "Select Font" dialog for an example.)
2. The buttons should all have the same height, which normally is 12 pixels.
3. Set all of the push buttons to have the same group ID; any nonzero value will work. The group ID only has to be unique for the form; two forms could have groups with the same ID without any interaction or overlap. Usually the group ID is 1, and if a second group exists on the same form, it could use group ID 2.
4. Usually, you place a label next to the push buttons, making sure that the baseline of the label matches the baseline of the text inside the push buttons.

Inside your `frmOpenEvent` handler, you should call `FrmSetControlGroupSelection` to determine which selection is the default. You pass this function the ID of the push button that should be turned on.

To get the selection, call `FrmGetControlGroupSelection`. This function returns the index of the active push button -- not the ID like `FrmSetControlGroupSelection` takes. You might want to use `FrmGetObjectId` to convert this index back into the control ID.

You are sent a `ctlSelectEvent` when the user taps a push button. This event contains the ID of the selected button.